# phi adajar

they/them
mit department of economics
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## education

2021– PhD Candidate in Economics, MIT (expected June 2027)
Dissertation: "Essays on the Economics of Education"
2017–2021 SB in Mathematical Economics, MIT

## research

fields — Primary: Education, Labor; Secondary: Development, Empirical Market Design
advisors — Parag Pathak, Esther Duflo, Nikhil Agarwal

### papers

1 link **The Winner's Curse in Test-Blind Admissions (Job Market Paper)**
with Nagisa Tadjfar and Kartik Vira.

2 link **Identifying and Nurturing Math Talent: Evidence from Tamil Nadu**
with Esther Duflo, Glenn Ellison, Sara Fisher Ellison, and Harini Kannan.
*Presented by coauthor at NBER Economics of Talent Meeting, Fall 2025; NBER Economics of Education Meeting, Spring 2026.*

3 link **A Practitioner's Guide to Estimating School Effects in Centralized Assignment Systems**

### in-progress

1 **From Cubs to Bears: The Evolution of Charter Effectiveness in Chicago**

2 **School-House Shocks: The Effect of Neighborhood-based School Assignment Policies on Intracity Migration**

### affiliations

2022– Blueprint Labs, Research Associate

### research assistantships

2022 Parag Pathak, MIT
2020 Benjamin Olken and Gabriel Kreindler, MIT + Harvard
2018–2021 Ernst Berndt and Rena Conti, MIT

### undergraduate work

2021 link Evaluating Strategic Play: Manipulations with Symmetric Information in the Boston Mechanism
Thesis advised by Parag Pathak.

2021 link A Rising Tide for All or Wave for One? The Effect of Charter School Competition on District Achievement
Selected for MIT Undergraduate Journal of Economics, Vol. XX.

2019 link The Surprising Hybrid Pedigree of Measures of Diversity and Economic Concentration
with Ernst Berndt and Rena Conti. NBER Working Paper #26512.

## teaching

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|---|---|
| 2025 | Kaufman Teaching Certificate, MIT Teaching + Learning Lab |
| 2023 | MIT 14.19 (UG Market Design), TA for Parag Pathak (rating 6.6/7) |
| 2021 | MIT 14.02 (UG Principles of Macroeconomics), TA for Ricardo Caballero (rating 6.5/7) |
| 2019 | MIT 14.27 (UG Economics and E-Commerce), TA for Sara Fisher Ellison (rating 5.8/7) |

## leadership + service

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| refereeing | *Econometrica*, *The Review of Economics and Statistics* |
| 2025– | Graduate representative, MIT Committee on Undergraduate Admissions and Financial Aid |
| 2022– | Graduate resident advisor, MIT Division of Student Life |
| 2023 | Graduate representative, MIT GRA Training Committee |
| 2022–2023 | Labor coffee organizer, MIT Department of Economics |
| 2021–2024 | Educational counselor (admissions interviewer), MIT Alumni Association |
| 2020–2021 | Undergraduate representative, MIT Committee on the Undergraduate Program |
| 2020– | Alumni volunteer, National Science Bowl |
| 2019–2021 | Regional/invitational coordinator, invitational founder, MIT Science Bowl |
| 2017–2021 | Chair, program director, MIT Educational Studies Program |

## awards + fellowships

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| 2025–2026 | Jerry A. Hausman Dissertation Fellowship, MIT Department of Economics |
| 2025–2026 | NBER Doctoral Dissertation Fellowship, Global Math Talent |
| 2021–2026 | NSF Graduate Research Fellowship |
| 2021 | Phi Beta Kappa, MIT |
| 2020 | Burchard Scholar, MIT |

## grants

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|---|---|
| uk unraveling | |
| 2023–2026 | George and Obie Shultz Fund ($64,500) |
| math talent | |
| 2025, 2026 | Carina Initiatives ($4,300,000) |
| 2024 | Founders Pledge (£310,000) |
| 2023, 2024 | Agency Fund ($600,000) |
| 2023 | J-PAL Science for Progress Initiative ($72,000) |

## potpourri

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| music/theater | Carnavale di Oscurità (Incantrix Productions, 2027), Blood Hunt: A Comedy Vampire Bar Crawl (Incantrix Productions, 2026), The Wedding Party (Secret City Adventures/Green Door Labs, 2026), Romancing Jan: Love and Labor (Incantrix Productions, 2026), Michael in “tick, tick… BOOM!” (MIT KAST!, 2024), Kevin in “Remembering Her” (MIT, 2023), Centrifugues Music Director (2022) |
| puzzlehunts | Strategy captain for NES (4$^{th}$ place MIT Mystery Hunt 2025+2026, 2027 MIT MH pre-hunt writing team), puzzle writer for Green Door Labs (Cthulhu Luau, Club Drosselmeyer), consultant for FableVision Studios (HMNH Puzzle Party) |
| crosswords | Daily NYT solving since 2022, perennial Boswords competitor, author for 2025 MIT Crossword Open |
| interests | D&D, trivia, jazz piano, baking, biking |